PART IV · CHORDS · TIPS

# When a chord sounds wrong

A chord that sounds wrong usually has one small slip. Name the slip, fix that one note, and the chord comes right.

TIP

### What you notice, what to check

| WHAT YOU NOTICE | CHECK | TURN TO |
|---|---|---|
| A chord sounds dark when it should be bright | **the kind**: keys between, 3 + 2 or 2 + 3 | p. 90 |
| Your hand jumps all over | **an inversion**: keep the shared note still | p. 96 |
| A big chord sounds muddy | **leave notes out**: drop the 5th first | p. 105 |
| A seventh chord sounds wrong | **the 7th**: G7 adds F, a 7th above G (9 keys between) | p. 99 |
| A sus chord sounds unfinished | **the 4th**: the middle layer moved up a letter | p. 102 |
| The bass note sounds odd | **the slash**: the letter after it is the lowest note | p. 108 |

## Four ways to learn chords fast

1. **Build, then play**
   Say the cake (C E G) before your fingers go down.

2. **Hands alone first**
   Left hand chords alone, then the tune alone, then together.

3. **One cake, three keys**
   Build the same kind of chord on C, G and F.

4. **Listen for the kind**
   Play major and minor side by side: bright, then dark.

EXAMPLE

### Fix a dark chord




1. **It sounds dark**, but the music wants a bright C chord.
2. **Count the keys between:** C to E♭, then E♭ to G. Which kind is that?
3. **Move one note** so it becomes 3 + 2. Which layer, and to which key?

Move the middle layer from E♭ up to **E**: 3 + 2, bright C major again.

THINK OF IT Like a mechanic: one odd sound points to one part. Fix that part and the engine runs smoothly.